EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 10 OCTOBER 2026 · VERIFIED RUN

El Cerrito, California (ZIP 94530)

A strong El Niño roughly doubles the odds of a very wet winter here, and in El Cerrito a wet winter means power cuts. Most of the people at risk are the 176 residents on powered medical equipment. PG&E's backup-battery programs do not cover storm outages, so the single most useful thing is a battery lending pool, ready before the first atmospheric river. The hills slide too, and they have since the 1950s.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
The Climate Impact Lab region containing western Contra Costa County (name not resolved)	None published for the US, California, or the county	Jun 2026 – Feb 2027 (heat only; not this hazard)	Storm power outages; hillside landslides; generator carbon monoxide; tide-and-storm flooding at Creekside Park

18/18 recommendations verified. 2 confirmed, 9 corrected (partially confirmed), 1 unverified, 6 contraindicated. The funding target moved from $145k to about $123k, down 15%, so the envelope stands. **The El Niño premise was tested, not assumed:** we classed 36 winters of daily rainfall at Richmond, next to El Cerrito, by the official El Niño index. **The run's sharpest finding** was confirmed in verification: PG&E's backup batteries are offered "only during Public Safety Power Shutoffs," so in a winter storm outage they reach almost no one here. **Method caveat:** the session's web-search budget ran out during verification;

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



37.92°N 122.30°W, United States of America · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** A wet winter here means power cuts and slides: 176 residents rely on powered medical equipment, PG&E's backup-battery programs do not cover storm outages, and the city has mapped 26 slides.
- **First action.** El Cerrito Fire, Kensington Fire, Meals on Wheels, and city senior services list residents on powered equipment by 15 November, enroll them, and give each a named person who calls within two hours of an outage.
- **The money.** About $56k floor, $123k target, $300k ceiling; it goes to backup power, a check-in roster, and carbon-monoxide alarms.
- **Do not.** Do not count on a portable battery to keep an oxygen concentrator running: a 2 kWh station lasts about 3 to 6 hours, and storm outages here often last a day or more.*

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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

later checks worked by direct fetch, and the items they could not reach are marked unverified.

DOES EL NIÑO MATTER HERE? THE PREMISE, TESTED

Richmond daily rainfall (NOAA GHCN-Daily), October to March, winters 1973–74 to 2024–25, keeping the 36 winters with at least 90% of days reported. Only three strong El Niño winters pass that test, so read every difference as a tilt, not a rule.

WINTERS	OCT–MAR RAIN (MM)	DAYS WITH 25 MM OR MORE	LARGEST 3-DAY TOTAL (MM)	WINTERS WITH A 3-DAY TOTAL OF 100 MM OR MORE
Strong El Niño (3)	922	12.0	104	1 of 3
Moderate or weak El Niño (8)	477	4.9	90	3 of 8
Neutral (13)	556	6.4	95	5 of 13
La Niña (12)	483	4.3	84	2 of 12
All winters (36)	544	5.8	91	11 of 36

- **Two winters drive the signal.** 1982–83 (1,048 mm) and 1997–98 (1,076 mm) were about double normal. 2015–16, the strongest El Niño on record, was only modestly wet here (641 mm). Strength did not predict rain.
- **The risk shows up as repeated soaking days.** Strong winters roughly doubled the days with 25 mm or more, but barely changed the odds of a single extreme 3-day storm. That pattern saturates slopes and brings down trees on lines.
- **What NOAA says now.** *"El Niño continues to strengthen, with a strong-to-very strong El Niño likely through January-March 2027"* (CPC, 8 October 2026). The seasonal outlook favors wetter-than-normal conditions near the California coast, at 50 to 60 percent, for December to April (CPC, 17 September 2026).

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

EXPOSURE, HONESTLY

WHO IS AT RISK, AND FROM WHAT

- **An older ZIP code.** 20.7% of ZIP 94530's 26,401 residents are 65 or over (17.1% county-wide), 2,359 are 75 or over, and about 1,698 people aged 65 or over live alone. 25.4% of those 65 or over report a disability (ACS 2024, 5-year).
- **People whose lives run on electricity.** 176 Medicare beneficiaries in the ZIP use electricity-dependent medical equipment, 34 use home oxygen, and 14 rely on dialysis (HHS emPOWER, queried 10 October 2026).
- **Outages are the hazard that reliably arrives.** In the January 2023 atmospheric river about 5,500 customers in the Berkeley Hills, Kensington, and El Cerrito lost power, and in February 2025 6,306 customers in Richmond and El Cerrito did (news reports, not re-checked).
- **The hills slide, and nobody insures it.** A USGS study of 1950–71 found that "Orinda and El Cerrito have been particularly susceptible." About 80% of damaging slides started on cut or fill slopes. Standard California homeowners policies exclude earth movement, and flood insurance covers mudflow but not landslides, so a rain-triggered slide is paid for by the owner.
- **Flooding is narrow.** 26 flood-insurance claims in the ZIP since 1978 (about $123,000 in building payouts), concentrated where Cerrito Creek's old marsh floods when winter runoff meets a high tide.
- **Many households speak another language.** 36.1% speak a language other than English at home: Chinese (1,167 who speak English less than "very well") and Spanish (700) lead.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO

RANKED BY LIVES PER EFFORT

Actions 1 to 4 protect the people an outage kills: those on powered equipment, the old and alone, and anyone who runs a generator indoors. Actions 5 and 6 cover the rest of winter. Actions 7 to 9 are about the hills.

1. Build the list of residents on powered medical equipment, enroll them in Medical Baseline and the county alert system, and give each a named person who calls within two hours of an outage

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · FRONTLINE · PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND FOR THE US

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
El Cerrito Fire and Kensington Fire; Meals on Wheels Diablo Region; city senior services	Lists by 15 November	$30k check-in roster (estimate; see funding)	Someone on oxygen, dialysis, or a powered bed going unchecked through a long outage

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Medical Baseline gives about 500 kWh a month at the lowest rate and extra outage notifications by call, text, or doorbell. Meals on Wheels Diablo Region (FY2025 revenue $6.6M) runs Friendly Visitors and Callers with wellness check-ins. The 2003 New York City blackout raised accidental deaths by 122% and other deaths by 25%, about 90 excess deaths, against 6 officially counted (Anderson and Bell 2012); it was a summer outage, so treat the transfer to winter as indirect.

Corrections: whether Meals on Wheels' Friendly Visitors serve West County now is unconfirmed, and $30k is an assumed half-time role, not a published cost. Enrollment in Medical Baseline is not a guarantee of a warning, so pair it with the named caller.

2. Stock a battery lending pool for storm outages through Independent Living Resource of Contra Costa, screening residents for PG&E's own programs first and claiming PG&E's battery rebate for hill households

CONFIRMED | PHILANTHROPIST · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Independent Living Resource of Contra Costa County (Concord), PG&E's disability-access center for the county	**Units in place by 1 December**	**$71,940 for 60 units (see funding)**	**Powered beds, CPAPs, and chairs failing in a day-long storm outage**

PG&E's disability-access batteries are "only available during Public Safety Power Shutoffs." Its Portable Battery Program requires a shutoff since 2024 or three trips on a fast-trip circuit, and it is closed for 2026. Winter storm outages meet neither test. The Generator and Battery Rebate (up to $300, plus $200 for CARE and FERA customers) applies to addresses in a High Fire-Threat District: verification found Tier 2 and Tier 3 areas in the El Cerrito hills and Kensington, but none in the flats.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

A 2 kWh lithium iron phosphate station lists at about $1,199. Check every unit against current recalls. Not for oxygen concentrators: see Do not do this.

3. Put sealed battery carbon-monoxide alarms in owner-occupied homes in the outage-prone streets, and tell every household in Chinese and Spanish: no generator, grill, or gas oven indoors

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · EMERGENCY MGR · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
CERT volunteers with the fire departments' prevention staff	1 December	$21k for 600 alarms (price unverified)	Carbon-monoxide deaths from generators run indoors

In New Mexico, alarms "may have prevented approximately half" of 136 unintentional carbon-monoxide deaths over 1980–95, and 36% of victims were probably asleep (Yoon, JAMA 1998); that is a modelled estimate, not a trial. California has required carbon-monoxide alarms since 2011 in homes with fuel-burning appliances or an attached garage, so landlords already owe them to renters; target owner-occupiers. El Cerrito Fire installs smoke detectors for residents 65 and over but says, "We do not install carbon monoxide alarms."*

In the January 2023 storms two men died at Sea Ranch with a generator running in a hallway, the failure mode this action targets. No distributor is yet named.

4. Run a Medical Baseline, CARE and FERA, and energy-assistance (LIHEAP) enrollment drive this month

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
City senior services; volunteers; Contra Costa EHSD for LIHEAP	LIHEAP applications in October	Staff and volunteer time; benefits paid by PG&E ratepayers and federal LIHEAP	Households rationing heat or power through the wet months

LIHEAP takes about six weeks to process, so October filings land before the peak. The 2026 income limit is $6,407 a month for a household of four. Apply at CALIHEAPApply.com or 925-655-0960.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: priority points now apply, so past recipients may be refused; no 2026 crisis maximum was published, so none is given here.

5. Vaccinate residents 75 and over before December: high-dose flu, COVID, and RSV

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Contra Costa Health clinics; pharmacies; primary-care practices	Mid-December	Covered by Medicare	Flu and RSV deaths, which outnumber storm deaths and are never counted as storm deaths

High-dose flu vaccine gave 24.2% more protection against laboratory-confirmed flu than the standard dose in adults 65 and over (DiazGranados, NEJM 2014; industry-funded). RSV vaccine was 75% effective against RSV hospitalization in adults 60 and over in its first season, and 76% in those 75 and over (Surie, JAMA 2024); over two seasons it fell to 68% in those 75 and over. RSV is a single dose, not annual, for everyone 75 and over and for at-risk adults 50 to 74. California's flu uptake among people 65 and over is 65.5% (BRFSS 2024); no Contra Costa figure was found.*

The Public Health lens's one thing: the storm deaths will be the smallest part of this winter's toll. An oxygen user who decompensates three days into an outage is coded as a cardiac death.

6. Sign residents up for Contra Costa's alert calls and texts door to door, with a phone tree for people without smartphones

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | SKEPTIC · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Volunteers at the Recycling Center, the Senior Center, and Asian markets	Before the first atmospheric river	None	Hill residents missing an evacuation warning at night

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The 2024 Contra Costa civil grand jury found only about 30% of residents registered for the Community Warning System and recommended automatic registration. The county's compliance report lists that recommendation as implemented, but cwsalerts.com still asks residents to register. Wireless Emergency Alerts reach phones without registering; calls, texts, and landline alerts do not.

7. Pre-write evacuation-warning zones for the El Cerrito and Kensington hills, with a cumulative-rainfall trigger, a list of who needs a ride, and no parking on narrow hill streets on storm days

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
El Cerrito and Kensington fire chiefs with Contra Costa OES	30 November	Staff time	People caught in a slide on a road blocked by parked cars

The USGS study proposed a rainfall-based warning: widespread sliding came with storms over about 7 inches, but only after about 10 inches had already fallen that season. El Cerrito gets about 22 inches a year, so use a cumulative-plus-storm rule rather than storm totals alone. In the April 2022 evacuation drill, only 114 of 339 vehicles in the target zone took part (33%), and the drill report recommends traffic and parking changes.

Whether the National Weather Service issues debris-flow products outside burn scars could not be confirmed. Set the trigger locally with a geologist.

8. Clear storm drains, culverts, and creek inlets before the November king tides, paid from the Measure J storm-drain fund

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
El Cerrito Public Works	Before 24 November	Measure J Storm Drain Fund and operations budget	Creekside Park flooding when a storm meets a high tide

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

King tides fall on 24 to 26 November, 23 to 25 December, and 21 to 22 January. The city maintains 3.8 miles of open channels and creeks. In 1969 it built flood basins in Creekside Park, which reduced but did not end the tide-and-storm flooding.

Correction: the city's $7.5M Emergency Disaster Relief Fund is a disaster reserve, and using it for routine clearing would need a policy change; the storm-drain fund is the cleaner payer.

9. Check that warming centers, evacuation points, and the homes of medically vulnerable residents are not on mapped slides

CONFIRMED · HISTORIAN · ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
City planning with Contra Costa OES	30 November	Staff time	Sending people to shelter on the slope that is moving

The local precedent: in 2012 the school district demolished Portola Middle School as an "irremediable seismic hazard on an unstable slope" and rebuilt it on flat ground. The 2022 drill's destination, El Cerrito Plaza BART, is on the flats.

10. Put one trained CERT member on every hill street cluster

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · FRONTLINE · PHILANTHROPIST · ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
El Cerrito–Kensington CERT	Fall 2026 course	Not published	Streets with nobody trained when the phones are down

A May 2026 kickoff invited sign-ups for a fall course. Contact prepare@kensingtonfire.org or Fire Admin at 510-215-4450 to confirm dates.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Correction: no fee is published, so the $4k fee line was removed from the funding.

11. Ask PG&E to clear city trees leaning on overhead lines in the hills, logged by Public Works

UNVERIFIED | EMERGENCY MGR | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
El Cerrito Public Works with PG&E vegetation management	30 November	Staff time	Outages that last until a tree is cut off the line

In January 2023 a large tree fell in El Cerrito and cut a home's power, and PG&E could not reconnect until it was cleared. No formal city-PG&E joint-walk mechanism was found, so treat this as a request, not a program.

12. Restart the Geologic Hazard Abatement District for the Blakemont slide, for 2027

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · AFTER THE PEAK | HISTORIAN · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Property owners on the slide; the city council	Start now; for 2027	An assessment on the district's owners	Another decade of studied, unbuilt drainage on an active slide

California law lets owners of at least 10% of the land, or the council by resolution, start a district, which then needs a plan of control from a certified engineering geologist. Formation was being studied for Blakemont, on the El Cerrito–Kensington border, around 2005. No sign was found that a district was formed or the deep drains built.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	El Cerrito & Kensington Fire	CERT & volunteers	City senior services	Meals on Wheels Diablo	Independent Living Resource	PG&E	Contra Costa County (Health, OES, EHSD)	Public Works & planning	Property owners
1. List, enroll, and name a caller	**A/R**	**R**	**R**	**R**	**C**	**C**	**I**		
2. Battery lending pool	**C**		**C**		**A/R**	**C**			
3. CO alarms and generator warnings	**C**	**A/R**	**R**						
4. Medical Baseline, CARE/FERA, LIHEAP drive		**R**	**A/R**		**R**	**I**	**R**		
5. Vaccination for 75 and over			**R**				**A/R**		
6. Alert sign-up and phone tree	**C**	**A/R**	**R**				**C**		
7. Hillside warning zones and ride list	**A/R**	**R**	**C**				**R**	**R**	
8. Drains and culverts before king tides							**C**	**A/R**	
9. Shelters off mapped slides	**C**		**C**				**R**	**A/R**	
10. CERT on every hill cluster	**A/R**	**R**							
11. Trees on lines						**R**		**A/R**	
12. Blakemont hazard district								**C**	**A/R**

What the chart shows. **The fire departments are accountable for the three rows that decide who gets reached**: the list, the warning zones, and CERT. **The one row that needs real money, the battery pool, sits with a disability nonprofit** that already distributes PG&E batteries but has never run a storm-outage lending service. **PG&E is never accountable**: its programs stop at wildfire shutoffs, so every row about storm outages falls to local hands.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

Verified and corrected. The money goes to backup power for people on powered equipment, a check-in roster, and carbon-monoxide alarms, the three things that stand between an outage and a death here. Screen every battery recipient through PG&E's programs and the battery rebate first.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

FLOOR	TARGET	CEILING	LARGEST UNCERTAINTY
About $56k	About $123k	About $300k	How many of the 176 already have backup power, and whether Independent Living Resource can run a lending pool before December

Arithmetic. Floor: 30 batteries × $1,199 = $35,970 + 300 alarms × $35 = $10,500 + $10,000 check-ins = $56,470. Target: check-in roster $30,000 + 60 batteries × $1,199 = $71,940 + 600 alarms × $35 = $21,000 = $122,940. Ceiling, bounded by need: 176 batteries × $1,199 = $211,024 + 1,698 alarms × $35 = $59,430 + $30,000 = $300,454; the battery line alone would be about 9% of Independent Living Resource's annual revenue, so capacity, not need, may bind first. The $35 alarm price and the $30,000 roster are estimates. The target fell 15% from the lens's $145k: a cheaper, larger battery replaced the first model, and the unpublished CERT fee line was removed.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
Independent Living Resource of Contra Costa County	Action 2: battery lending pool for storm outages	$71,940	Restricted grant, stock in place by 1 December	60 × $1,199 (2,048 Wh LFP station, list price); FY2025 revenue $2.31M	Confirmed; not for oxygen concentrators
Meals on Wheels Diablo Region, with city senior services	Action 1: storm-day check-in roster	$30,000	Grant	Assumed 0.5 FTE for five months; FY2025 revenue $6.63M	Partially confirmed; West County coverage to confirm
CERT volunteers (distributor to be named)	Action 3: sealed battery CO alarms for owner-occupiers	$21,000	Bulk purchase and volunteer installs	600 × $35 (price unverified)	Partially confirmed; needs a named distributor
El Cerrito–Kensington CERT	Action 10: course fees	$0	Removed	No fee published	Unverified as a cost

The funder's one thing: PG&E's batteries switch on for wildfire shutoffs, and an atmospheric-river outage is not one. Without a local pool, the people in this ZIP who need power to stay alive have no backup in exactly the outages most likely to hit them.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Do not count on a portable battery to keep an oxygen concentrator running*

CONTRAINDICATED FOUND IN VERIFICATION

A 300–600 W concentrator runs about 3 to 6 hours on a 2 kWh station. Storm outages here often last a day or more.

Instead: the 34 home-oxygen users get backup cylinders from their oxygen supplier before December. Batteries are for CPAPs, powered beds, and chairs.

Do not tell residents to buy a generator*

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC; CONFIRMED

Generators must run at least 20 feet from the house, which is hard on El Cerrito's small hill lots, and indoor generators are a recurring cause of storm deaths.

Instead: battery stations through the lending pool or PG&E's rebate, and a carbon-monoxide alarm in every home (actions 2 and 3).

Do not hand out sandbags as the defense against hillside slides

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC; CONFIRMED

Sandbags redirect shallow water; they do not stop a debris flow.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: keep sandbags for the Creekside Park flats, and in the hills clear drains and use the warning zones (actions 7 and 8).

Do not tell people "you'll get an alert"

`CONTRAINDICATED (NARROWED)` `SKEPTIC; CORRECTED IN VERIFICATION`

Wireless Emergency Alerts reach phones without registering, but calls, texts, and landline warnings need sign-up, and only about 30% of residents had registered in 2024.

Instead: register people at the door and keep a phone tree (action 6).

Do not buy parametric insurance triggered by 24-hour rainfall at a local gauge

`CONTRAINDICATED` `CARRIED FROM THE ELMWOOD BRIEFING; CONFIRMED`

Debris flows follow short bursts on soaked slopes; a single gauge's 24-hour total does not measure where a slide runs, so the payout can miss the damage.

Instead: put the money into the battery pool and the hazard district.

Do not rely on the state's disaster utility protections before an emergency is declared

`CONTRAINDICATED` `CARRIED FROM THE ELMWOOD BRIEFING`

The CPUC's disaster customer protections apply after a declared state of emergency. They were not re-fetched in this run.

Instead: enroll households in Medical Baseline, CARE, FERA, and LIHEAP now (action 4).

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHAT HAS HAPPENED HERE BEFORE

THE RECORD

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
1950–71	Recurrent landslides; the city mapped 26 slides	"Orinda and El Cerrito have been particularly susceptible" (USGS)	USGS proposed a rainfall-based warning system; not built
1969	Tide-and-storm flooding at Cerrito Creek's old marsh	Not recorded	Creekside Park flood basins built
1982 (3–5 January)	Bay Area storm	33 deaths region-wide, 25 from landslides; Kensington's Beloit Ave slide closed the road for about a year	No El Cerrito deaths found
1997–98	Strong El Niño	About $27M of landslide damage in Contra Costa County	Not broken down by street
2005	Blakemont slide	Most homes on it damaged	Hazard district studied; not found built
2012	Portola Middle School	Condemned on an unstable slope	Demolished and rebuilt on flat ground
2023 (January)	Atmospheric rivers	About 5,500 customers without power in the hills; Richmond homes evacuated below Seacliff	Not found
2025 (13 February)	Storm outage	6,306 customers in Richmond and El Cerrito	Not found

The recurrence nobody has noticed: El Cerrito's slides are not new failures. They are ancient landslide complexes moving again, on small lots that put more households on each one. The fixes, geology-led zoning in the 1970s and the Blakemont district in the 2000s, were studied and not built.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — RESOLVED AND OPEN

- **Resolved: do PG&E's batteries cover this?** The Philanthropist said no; the Economist pointed residents to PG&E's programs. Verification sided with the Philanthropist: disability-access batteries are for shutoffs only, and the Portable Battery Program is gated and closed. The rebate is a partial exception for hill addresses.
- **Resolved: is the city broke?** One brief assumed a current fiscal emergency. Verification found reserves rebuilt to $21.1M and a disaster fund of $7.5M, though whether the State Auditor has lifted its high-risk rating was not confirmed.
- **Open: what landslide trigger?** The USGS rule was calibrated in Lafayette, where rain is heavier. Settle it with a local engineering geologist before December.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

Renters in the new mid-rise buildings near the BART stations. No lens examined who in those buildings depends on elevators or powered equipment, or who manages them in an outage. Second, **no lens found El Cerrito-specific damage records** for the 1982, 1998, or 2023 storms: the city's 2024 hazard-plan annex returned errors to every fetch.

HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

The panel is author-built. Seven simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people. They are not neighborhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; drought, flood, fire, smoke, and crop failure are additional to it and are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED — METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The location was taken as given: ZIP 94530, El Cerrito (with a small part of Richmond). Climate Impact Lab impact region: the one containing western Contra Costa County, name not resolved. Statistics are for the ZIP code tabulation area unless stated. Mortality figures

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

exist only at about 300,000 people; sub-city detail is used for hazards and actions, not death counts.

- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Where heat is not the dominant hazard, the historical record carries the hazard instead of a borrowed number.
- **Expert panel.** Seven simulated expert lenses (an emergency manager, a public health scientist, a frontline responder, a skeptic, an economist, a historian, and a philanthropist) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief. They were given the neighboring Elmwood (Berkeley) and San Francisco briefings' verified findings. An eighth agent tested the El Niño premise on NOAA station data (Richmond USC00047414; Redwood City and SFO as cross-checks).
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias (whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one) before it counted in an action's favour. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Five verifier agents checked every recommendation on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). Financial actions were also checked for availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether they already exist. The funding envelope was checked for real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Consulted earlier the same day by reading the dataset embedded in the inventory page: 96 entries. The US entries relevant here are winter weather advisories (fewer crashes with longer lead times) and flood-map misclassification; nothing covers backup power, carbon-monoxide alarms, or landslide warnings.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (vaccines and doses, oxygen and medical equipment in an outage, and generators and carbon monoxide) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so and shows the containing geography's number with its arithmetic. Every source is listed below with its verification status.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. The session's web-search budget ran out during verification; later checks worked by direct fetch. Unreachable or unconfirmed: the city's 2024 hazard-plan annex (403), PSPS history in El Cerrito since 2020, the outage counts (news reports), the CPUC disaster-protection terms, Meals on Wheels' West County coverage, and current alarm prices.

References · Premise: CPC Oceanic Niño Index · GHCN-D Richmond (fetched) · CPC ENSO discussion, 8 Oct 2026 (verified) · CPC long-lead discussion (verified)
People: ACS 2024 5-year, ZCTA 94530 · HHS emPOWER (queried)
Power: PG&E DDAR fact sheet (verified) · DDAR · Portable Battery Program (verified) · Generator and Battery Rebate (verified) · Medical Baseline (verified) · Storm inconvenience credits (verified) · CPUC Fire Threat Tiers layer (queried) · Berkeley Scanner, Jan 2023 · EcoFlow price list
Warning and slides: Grand jury report 2402 (verified) · Compliance report 2501 (verified) · Community Warning System · 2022 evacuation drill report (verified) · USGS Bulletin 1388 (verified) · USGS PP 1434, January 1982 storm · USGS 1997–98 Contra Costa landslides · CGS, hazard abatement districts (verified) · Portola demolition (verified) · El Cerrito–Kensington CERT (verified)
Money and flood: El Cerrito Budget in Brief FY27–28 (verified) · State Auditor 2020-803 (verified) · LIHEAP 2026 packet (verified) · OpenFEMA NFIP claims API (queried) · CDI landslide fact sheet (verified) · King tides 2026–27 (verified) · Cerrito Creek (secondary) · Independent Living Resource 990 (verified) · Meals on Wheels Diablo Region 990 (verified) · El Cerrito Fire, smoke and CO detectors (verified)
Health: DiazGranados 2014 (verified) · Surie 2024, RSV (verified) · California flu uptake 65+ (verified) · Yoon 1998, CO alarms (verified) · Anderson and Bell 2012, blackout mortality (verified) · Sea Ranch generator deaths, 2023 (verified)
Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory
Generated 10 October 2026 for El Cerrito, California (ZIP 94530). El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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